

The Record

A second document, on the organisation that published your Bible.

If you have arrived here, you have read the previous document, or enough of it to decide it was worth checking. This one asks a different kind of question, and a harder one, so it is worth being clear at the outset about what it is and what it is not.

It is not about whether the men who lead your organisation are good men. That question is not asked anywhere in this document and nothing here depends on the answer. There is no material about anyone's private life and there are no claims about anyone's motives. What is discussed is published material: things printed, dated and distributed, which anyone can look up.

It is not a claim that being wrong is disqualifying. Every religious body has been wrong about something, and the balance note at the end names the cases outside your organisation, because leaving them out would be dishonest.

What it asks is narrower. There is a test in the Bible for people who speak in God's name. Your own publications have applied that test to others, and have invited it to be applied to themselves. This document takes up that invitation.

As before, every reference is given in full, with date and page, and most of them can be read in the Society's own

online library. Where a widely circulated claim turns out to be misdated or truncated, it is not used, and the last section says which ones and why.

What test does the Bible set for someone who speaks for God?

There are two tests, and they are placed close together in Deuteronomy. Both are worth reading in your own Bible before anything else here.

The first is Deuteronomy 18:20-22. It concerns a prophet who speaks presumptuously in Jehovah's name, and the test is plain: if what he says does not occur or come true, then Jehovah did not speak it, and the people need not be afraid of him.

The second is Deuteronomy 13:1-5, and it closes the other door. It concerns a prophet whose sign or portent *does* come true — and who then leads the people after other gods. The instruction is that the sign is not to be followed, because Jehovah is testing where his people's hearts really are.

Read together, and they are placed together deliberately, the two cover both failures. A man whose predictions fail is not speaking for God. A man whose predictions succeed but whose teaching leads elsewhere is not either.

The context in both cases is Israel about to enter a land full of competing religious claims, with no way to check them except by what happens. That is why the tests are practical rather than doctrinal: they are tests anyone could apply without training.

Which is what makes them usable now.

THE EVIDENCE

The second test matters for a reason worth stating plainly. It means this document cannot be answered by pointing to things the organisation got right, and it also means we cannot answer it that way ourselves. Accuracy alone settles nothing in either direction; Deuteronomy 13 exists precisely to say so.

Both passages should be read in the New World Translation rather than in any rendering supplied here. Nothing in this section turns on a translation question, and there is no dispute about the sense of either text.

What is the standard answer to this?

The answer is well known, it is consistent, and it is set out here first and in full, because an argument that will not survive the reply to it does not deserve to be made.

It runs like this. The organisation has never claimed inspiration. Its publications are the work of imperfect men doing their best with the light available, and when understanding has proved wrong it has been adjusted — which is what honest students of the Bible do. The prophets of Deuteronomy 18 spoke as inspired men delivering God's words directly. That is a different thing from a group of Bible students publishing their expectations and later correcting them. Proverbs 4:18 describes the path of the righteous as a light growing brighter, and adjustments are evidence of that brightening rather than against it.

That is a real answer and it does real work. If the organisation had only ever said “we think the Bible points to this date, and we may be wrong,” Deuteronomy 18 would not obviously apply, and this document would have very little to say.

Everything that follows is therefore aimed at one narrow question, and not at the general question of whether people may be wrong. The question is whether the organisation claimed a status that brings the test into play — and whether it set that test itself.

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The two sections that follow supply the evidence for that narrow question, and they are the only two on which the rest of the document depends. If either fails, the argument fails with it.

Neither is an outsider's characterisation. Both are the organisation's own published words, in its own magazine, and both can be read in its own online library.

What did the organisation call itself?

The Watchtower of 1 April 1972, pages 197 to 200, carries an article asking whether the modern world has a prophet to warn it.

Its answer is that it does, and that the prophet is not an individual but a group: the body of anointed Christians, identified with the organisation itself. The article makes the identification directly and at length, describing that body as the modern-day Ezekiel commissioned to give warning to Christendom.

What matters more than the claim is what the article does next. It anticipates the obvious objection — that saying so is easy — and answers it by pointing to the record. Proving the claim, it says, can be done only one way: by reviewing what the group has actually done.

That invitation is the reason this document exists in the form it does. It is not an outside critic demanding that the organisation submit to a test it never accepted. It is the organisation naming the category and then asking to be assessed on its record within it.

So the question of whether Deuteronomy 18 is the relevant standard is not one an outsider has to argue for. The category was chosen in print.

THE EVIDENCE

Source. ‘They Shall Know that a Prophet Was Among Them’, *The Watchtower*, 1 April 1972, pp. 197–200. Readable in full in the Watchtower Online Library.

The obvious objection, stated fairly. The article does not use the word inspired, and the position that the organisation has never claimed inspiration is not contradicted by it in so many words. A reader may reasonably hold that both statements can stand together.

Response. Perhaps they can. But Deuteronomy 18 is not a test of inspiration claimed; it is a test of words spoken in Jehovah’s name that do not come true. The article places the organisation in the prophet’s role and invites the record to be examined. Whatever else is true, the examination has been asked for.

SECTION FOUR

What test did the organisation set for others?

The Watch Tower of 15 May 1930, page 156, discusses how to recognise a false prophet. The occasion is the clergy's predictions about the First World War — that it would end all wars and make the world safe for democracy.

The reasoning is Deuteronomy's. Those predictions did not come true; therefore the men who made them are false prophets, and, in the magazine's own words, "the people should no longer trust them as safe guides."

Nothing in that is unusual. It is what the passage says. What makes it worth reproducing is that it is the organisation's own statement of the standard, in its own words, published under its own name, and applied to others.

Put sections three and four together and the position is this. The organisation identified itself as occupying the prophet's role. It invited its record to be examined. And it published, in its own pages, the test by which such a record should be judged.

None of that was supplied from outside. All of it was chosen.

die sacrificial deaths as did Jesus and would go to heaven. Their prophecies did not come true. Therefore they are false prophets; and the people should no longer trust them as safe guides, but should look to the Lord through his revealed Word for their instructions as to what is to occur on the earth in the future.

The Watch Tower, Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society, 15 May 1930, p. 156, column 1. Cropped to the passage quoted. Reproduced for criticism and review.

THE EVIDENCE

Source. *The Watch Tower*, 15 May 1930, p. 156. This issue predates the Society's online library, which begins at 1950, so it is reproduced from a scan of the printed page.

A fair caution. Stating a standard and later failing it is not, by itself, hypocrisy; people do hold themselves to standards they later fall short of. The point here is only that the standard is theirs, so it cannot be dismissed as an outsider's imposition.

The record, in order

1914. The year was taught in advance, for decades, as the end of the present order of things. Charles Taze Russell's *The Time Is At Hand* put it as an established truth that the kingdoms of this world would reach their final end, and God's Kingdom its full establishment, by the close of 1914.

Times of the Gentiles, we consider it an established truth that the final end of the kingdoms of this world, and the full establishment of the Kingdom of God, will be accomplished by the end of A. D. 1914. Then the prayer of the

C. T. Russell, *The Time Is At Hand* (Studies in the Scriptures, vol. 2), Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society, p. 99. Cropped to the sentence discussed.

When 1914 arrived and the order did not end, the teaching was not dropped but re-described: the year became the date of an invisible enthronement in heaven, an event that by its nature cannot be observed or falsified. That pairing is the point of this entry — not that a date passed, but that a prediction about the visible world was converted into a claim about the invisible one, with the date preserved.

1925. *Millions Now Living Will Never Die* (1920) taught that 1925 would see the return to earth of the faithful men of ancient times, and said so in terms of confident expectation rather than possibility.

new 8:11) Therefore we may confidently expect that 1925 will mark the return of Abraham,

J. F. Rutherford, *Millions Now Living Will Never Die*, International Bible Students Association, 1920, p. 89. Cropped to the sentence discussed.

When the year passed the expectation did not vanish at once: a property was acquired and deeded in 1929 in anticipation of those men's arrival and use of it. That is recorded here as evidence of how concretely the teaching was held, and for no other purpose.

The 1914 generation. The teaching that the generation alive in 1914 would not pass away before the end was held, taught and repeated for decades, and was the practical basis on which many people made decisions about work, education and family. It was abandoned in 1995.

THE EVIDENCE

Sources. *The Time Is At Hand*, 1889, p. 99 (see also p. 101 on the same expectation); *Millions Now Living Will Never Die*, 1920, p. 89; the deed of the San Diego property, 1929; *The Watchtower*, 1 November 1995, for the revision of the generation teaching.

What is not claimed. That every statement in these publications was framed as certainty. Some were hedged, and the hedging is real. What is claimed is that the expectations were published, taught and acted upon, which is not seriously disputed by anyone including the organisation.

1975

This entry has more space than the others because it is the best documented, the most recent of the major ones, and the one whose consequences are still within living memory.

In 1966 the book *Life Everlasting — in Freedom of the Sons of God* published a chronology placing the end of six thousand years of human existence in 1975, and drew attention to how fitting it would be for the thousand-year reign to follow. *The Watchtower* of 15 October 1966, pages 628 and 629, took the matter further.

What followed was not merely an idea in a book. *Our Kingdom Ministry* of May 1974, page 3, spoke approvingly of those who had sold homes and property in order to spend the remaining time in full-time service. *The Watchtower* of 15 October 1974, page 635, belongs in the same picture.

Then the date passed.

The Watchtower of 15 March 1980, pages 17 and 18, addressed the disappointment. It is worth reading in full rather than in summary, because it concedes more than most people expect: that considerable expectation was aroused, that cautionary statements were published alongside others implying probability rather than possibility, and that the latter contributed to the buildup.

The point of setting these out in order is not the chronology error. Chronologies get revised. The point is the sequence: an expectation was published, people were commended for acting on it in ways that were extremely difficult to undo, the

expectation failed, and the acknowledgement came five years later.

If you know someone who sold a house in 1974, this section is about them.

THE EVIDENCE

Sources, all readable in the Watchtower Online Library. *Life Everlasting* — in *Freedom of the Sons of God*, 1966; *The Watchtower*, 15 October 1966, pp. 628–29; *Our Kingdom Ministry*, May 1974, p. 3; *The Watchtower*, 15 October 1974, p. 635; *The Watchtower*, 15 March 1980, pp. 17–18.

Their own history says the same. The Society’s account of its own past records that the 1966 book pointed to 1975, that the book triggered much discussion at the conventions where it was released, and reproduces what was said from the platform at Baltimore when the question was raised directly. This entry does not depend on any outside source.

Stated fairly. Cautionary statements were published as well, and the 1980 article says so. The concession is that they were overshadowed — and that judgement is the organisation’s own, not ours.

A resting point

This is a good place to stop for a while, and a harder place to stop than any page in the previous document, so it is worth saying why the pause is offered at all.

What has been set out is a record: a category the organisation named for itself, a test it published, and several occasions on which expectations it taught did not happen. Nothing has been said about anyone's sincerity, and nothing here requires you to think that the men involved were dishonest. Sincere people can be badly wrong, and often are.

But some of what you have just read may be about your own family. If your parents made decisions in the 1970s that cost them something, that is not an abstraction and it should not be read as one.

The last section asks one question and does not answer it. It will still be here tomorrow.

What is the trust resting on?

There is one question left, and it belongs to you rather than to this document.

The organisation identified itself as filling the prophet's role. It published the test by which such claims should be judged. On the occasions where its published expectations could be checked against events, they did not hold — and in the clearest case, people were encouraged to act on the expectation in ways that were costly and permanent.

Through all of it the authority remained exactly where it was. That is the part worth thinking about, and it is a different question from whether anyone was wrong.

So: if men who ask for this degree of trust — trust that shapes what you study, whom you marry, what work you take and whom you may speak to — have been wrong on this scale, and have said so themselves afterwards, what is the trust resting on?

That question is not rhetorical and it is not answered here. Answering it for you would be doing the one thing this document has tried throughout not to do.

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Balance. Date-setting failure is not unique to this organisation, and saying so costs nothing. William Miller and his followers expected the return of Christ in 1844, and a good number of evangelical episodes since have run the same course, some of them recently and embarrassingly.

The distinguishing claim is therefore not that the organisation erred. It is that it named the commission, published the test, did not meet it, and retained the authority. Each of those four is documented above, and each is documented from its own publications.

Arguments we are not using, and why

This document's list. The previous document has its own.

Anything about the private lives of individual officers.

Housing, salaries, personal conduct, court appearances. It is beside the point, it is the fastest way to lose a reader, and the published record carries the argument without it. That is also why the 1929 property appears above as evidence of a teaching rather than as a story about a man.

Speculation about motive. Whether anyone knew a teaching was wrong when they published it is unknowable and unnecessary. Every argument above works identically whether the men involved were sincere or not, and sincerity is assumed throughout.

The widely circulated 1917 and 1918 quotations about the fall of the churches. Several versions in common use are truncated at the point where the sense changes. Dropped rather than repaired.

Quotations whose dates are commonly given wrongly. A number of 1975-related lines circulate with confident dates that do not match the scans. Where a citation could not be checked against the page, it is not here.

The claim that no adjustment was ever acknowledged. It is false. The 1980 article appears above precisely because the acknowledgement exists, and a document that pretended otherwise would collapse the moment a reader found it.

Anything resting on a single unscanned secondary source. Several well-known items in the counter-cult literature trace back to one book quoting another book. They may well be accurate. They are not used.

Comparisons to other groups used as insult. The comparison in the box above is there to be fair, not to associate anyone with anything.

If anything in this document is misdated, misattributed or misquoted, it should be said, and it will be corrected. A wrong citation here costs more than any additional argument could gain.